

Occupy and challenge the center

Opening Decisions

THE IDEA

Central squares give pieces routes toward both wings. You can influence them with pawns or pieces, but you must notice when the opponent can undermine your support. A large pawn center needs development behind it.

WORKED EXAMPLE

After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4, White immediately challenges Black's central pawn. If Black captures on d4, White must recapture or otherwise justify the pawn loss; opening the center creates concrete obligations.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Why is pushing two central pawns not a complete opening strategy?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Those pawns can become targets. Pieces must develop, the king needs safety, and central exchanges must be calculated. Occupation without support can leave a fragile center.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Build a center that your pieces can maintain or transform.